friendship has become lore. In hugely popular, apocryphal stories of a clever courtier outwitting his kindly though none-too-bright lord, Mahesh Das appears as Birbal – a corruption of the title Akbar gave him, Birbar, ‘great warrior’.

Despite the title, however, when Akbar made Birbar governor of Nagarkot,[9] just before leaving for Gujarat, it was Akbar’s commander and governor of neighbouring Punjab, Husain Quli Khan, who went to war against Nagarkot’s raja on Birbar’s behalf.

As part of their siege of the steeply rising Himalayan fort, the Mughals attacked a temple that stood outside its walls. It was a bloody sack. Badauni describes ‘arrows and bullets . . . falling like drops of rain’ upon the brahmin priests and holy cows who lived within the shrine. Husain Quli’s assault was as much psychological as it was military, it seems, for Badauni relates how many of his soldiers, ‘through their zeal and excessive hatred of idolatry . . .
filled their shoes full of blood, and threw it on the doors and walls of the temple’. Such was the desecration that ‘friends and strangers heap a thousand thousands of curses on the head of Birbar, who reckoned himself a saint among the Hindus’ – and in whose name the carnage was committed.[10]

A Shia like Husain Quli Khan, disdained by his Sunni colleagues, running a bloody campaign for a brahmin courtier by assaulting a shrine is not the usual template of bigotry. Instead, it may be telling of the changing affiliations and antagonisms that propelled Akbar’s world, the dynamics of which were being transformed by Akbar’s policies.

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To return, however, to the two men presenting themselves to Akbar in muggy May.

Badauni, who may have come to court because his career seems to have been floundering under Husain Khan, was fond of his employer, and vice versa. Husain Khan gave Badauni a Persian horse worth 500 rupees at their very first meeting, and soon appointed him his *sadr* – religious judge – administering some of the khan’s fiefs. And yet, for all that the two men may have shared both sect and points of view – certainly when it came to